Qiyuan Zheng

qiyuan.zheng@princeton.edu ∘ www.qiyuanzheng-econ.github.io ∘ 508-847-5581

Placement Director	Gianluca Violante	violante@princeton.edu	609-258-4016
Graduate Administrator	Laura Hedden	lhedden@princeton.edu	609-258-4006

Office Contact Information

Julis Romo Rabinowitz Building
Department of Economics
Princeton University
Princeton, NJ 08544

Graduate Studies

Princeton University *2021-present*

PhD Candidate in Economics
Expected Completion Date: June 2027

References

Professor Pietro Ortoleva
Department of Economics
Princeton University
609-986-6895
pietro.ortoleva@princeton.edu

Professor Xiaosheng Mu
Department of Economics
Princeton University
(203) 909-2814
xmu@princeton.edu

Professor Sylvain Chassang
Department of Economics
Princeton University
609-258-4035
chassang@princeton.edu

Prior Education

Wesleyan University *2020-2021*

M.A. in Mathematics

Wesleyan University *2016-2020*

B.A. in Economics and Mathematics

Fields

Primary	Microeconomic Theory, Information Design
Secondary	Behavioral Economics

Job Market Paper

"Regulating Discretion through Information" 2026.

An agent makes decisions for an organization and privately knows how different factors contribute to their shared objectives. The agent also pursues private objectives that the organization does not share. To limit the influence of private objectives while preserving the agent's discretion, the organization offers a menu of disclosure rules, each specifying what the agent learns about the factors relevant to the decision. Information useful for pursuing shared objectives can help serve private objectives. This creates incentives for the agent to misrepresent how different factors contribute to shared objectives when choosing a disclosure rule. I characterize the optimal menu. The optimal rules generally depart from the agent's judgment about the relative importance of factors contributing to shared objectives. The threshold for action can depend directly on a factor that enters only the agent's private objective; banning its direct use can distort the weights assigned to the other factors that contribute to the shared objective.

Working Papers

1. "Strategically Ambiguous Deterrence." With Yiying Tan. 2026.

   We study efficient deterrence when agents are ambiguity averse. We show that a principal can implement deterrence more efficiently by obfuscating over conditional punishments associated with each level of compliance. However, obfuscation introduces endogenous limits to the range of outcomes the principal can achieve: perceived consequences depend on observable rates of compliance, which in turn result from agents' perceptions. We characterize the set of perceived consequences obfuscation can sustain: crucially, the perception of harsh consequences for severe non-compliance requires a critical mass of partial compliers. Under an obfuscated policy, the principal has reduced flexibility over how agents perceive differences in consequences across levels of non-compliance. We derive sufficient conditions for when the principal prefers obfuscation versus transparency. A principal may prefer transparency when the marginal effort of partial compliance is so costly that obfuscation cannot sustain a perceived gap between partial compliance and severe non-compliance large enough to deter the latter.

2. "Mixed Signals with Hidden Sources" 2026.

   I study the value of information when a decision-maker cannot observe the underlying signal structure. I first show that, even with flexible signal relabeling, mixing in a more informative source can worsen decisions when the source of each signal is hidden. This motivates an information-design problem: how should a fact-checker improve a news feed when she cannot credibly verify her reports to readers. More specifically, when is truth-telling optimal? For binary-action problems, I characterize when truth-telling is optimal at every level of the fact-checker's influence. When existing reports recommends both actions, appropriately relabeling and garbling the more accurate source preserves those responses and eliminates the welfare cost of hidden sources.

Work in Progress

1. "Multi-Stage Application Processes for Distributional Concerns" 2026.

Research Experience

2022 Research Assistant to Prof. Sylvain Chassang

Teaching

Princeton ECO 501: Graduate Microeconomics I (TA, Fall 2023, Fall 2024, Fall 2025)

ECO 300: Undergraduate Microeconomics (TA, Spring 2024)

Professional Activities

Refereeing

American Economic Review

Honors, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Grants

Goldfeld Summer Fellowship, Princeton University *2025*

William S. Dietrich II Economic Theory Center Summer Grant, Princeton University *2024*

Marimar & Cristina Torres Prize, Princeton University *2023*

Languages

English (native), Chinese (working proficiency)

Work Authorization

U.S. permanent resident

Last updated: October 2026